‘Less than half of the sepoys were by this stage fit for duty,’ wrote Vincent Eyre. ‘The cold had so nipped the hands and feet of even the strongest men, as to completely prostrate their powers and incapacitate them for service.’ Even the cavalry were ‘obliged to be lifted on their horses . . . Large clods of hardened snow adhered so firmly to the hoofs of our horses, that a chisel and hammer would have been requisite to dislodge them. The very air we breathed froze in its passage out of the mouth and nostrils, forming a coating of small icicles on our moustaches and beards . . . Already only a few hundred serviceable fighting-men remained.’[32]

If the bodies of the soldiers were severely weakened, their resolve and self-control was even more badly affected. ‘About ½ past 7 a.m. the advance guard moved off without any order given or bugle being sounded,’ recorded Hugh Johnson in his diary. ‘Discipline is at an end.’[33] The remaining baggage had not even been lifted on to the camels and oxen before large numbers of Afghans began to dart down the mountain slopes, plundering all that they could lay their hands on. Three cannon being dragged by mules were passing a small mudbrick fort close to the camp ground when a party of Afghans sallied straight out and captured them. The sepoys supposed to guard the artillery immediately ran off. As the troops advanced on their road, the number of mounted Afghans around them steadily increased. They travelled parallel to the British, on both flanks of the column, firing randomly into the jostling rabble of refugees they were now driving between them, like shepherds expertly controlling a flock of panicked sheep, the terrified sepoys having already lost all will to fight back.

One entire Hindustani regiment – Shah Shuja’s 29th – went over en masse to Akbar Khan that morning. Many other sepoys, already too frostbitten to continue, now threw down their weapons and fled back to Kabul, hoping that their injuries would preserve them from the attention of the town’s slavers, and anyway ‘preferring to become prisoners there to the certain death which they saw clearly must result from continuing any longer with the main body’. Months later, several hundred maimed former sepoys were still to be seen hobbling on their stumps, begging around the Kabul bazaars.

Although there was now hardly any food or ammunition left to see the main force through to Jalalabad, Elphinstone still called a halt in the middle of the second afternoon at Butkhak, at the mouth of the great Khord Kabul